
Wimbledon awards 2026: best player, epic matches, biggest drama and more

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Best player

It takes a certain amount of toughness and inner belief to keep moving forward after an excruciating setback. In the last match **Jannik Sinner** played before Wimbledon, he was on the receiving end of a shocking collapse in his French Open [second-round loss to Juan Manuel Cerúndolo](#). He responded by gradually building in every round, turning in a flawless [6-4, 6-4, 6-4 win over Novak Djokovic](#). Then he elevated his level against a peaking Alexander Zverev to [defeat the new No 2 in four sets](#). Sinner's run to a fifth grand slam title showcased his dramatic serve improvements, defensive skills, drop shots and lobs alongside the clean, vicious ball-striking that defines his play.

Most courageous performance

Linda Noskova made a frantic escape from Centre Court during the women's final in the midst of potentially one of the most painful collapses of all time. Noskova led her compatriot Karolina Muchova 6-2, 5-2 before she squandered five championship points, conceded five consecutive games and found herself in a third set. On her way to the bathroom, Noskova found herself [face-to-face with the Venus Rosewater Dish](#) and the runner-up plate.

Seeing the trophy at such a pivotal moment in the championship match would have been disruptive for many, only reinforcing the fact it had slipped from their grasp. For Noskova, however, it made her

even more desperate to ensure she left the court with that trophy. Noskova's recovery to [win her first grand slam title](#) was an impressive exhibition of her resilience.

Best match(es)

Women's round of 16: (Karolina Muchova bt Barbora Krejcikova 7-5, 5-7, 6-3 Do not listen to anyone who claims that modern tennis is solely the domain of thoughtless ball bashing. The [all-Czech fourth-round](#) match between Krejcikova, the 2024 champion, and Muchova was as dreamy in real life as it was on paper. They are two of the most skilful players around, armed with beautiful but potent all-round games with vast toolboxes of shots. This match showcased the full array of their capabilities. They threw everything at each other, trying to outmanoeuvre their opponent with sweet drop shots, unflinching net play, vicious slices, angles, precision serving and perfectly timed early forehands, all delivered in their own unique, effortless styles. It was just perfect.

Men's quarter-final: [Novak Djokovic bt Félix Auger-Aliassime 7-6 \(1\) 3-6, 6-3, 6-7 \(4\), 7-6 \(4\)](#) Five hours into his quarter-final battle with an opponent 14 years younger, it would have been perfectly understandable if Djokovic was fading physically or struggling to manage his stress. Instead, he locked his game down, refusing to miss throughout the final set tie-break, and closed out a scarcely believable victory. Djokovic did not win the title, but at 39, the level he continues to perform at is astounding. This five-hour, 15-minute epic, in which Auger-Aliassime also fought desperately hard, serving brilliantly until the tie-break, was a spectacular match and another reminder of his greatness.

Biggest surprise

[Arthur Fery's semi-final run](#). Not even the most bullish Fery supporter could possibly have imagined how his fortnight would unfold. He arrived at the All England Club, a short walk away from his mother's home, needing a main draw wildcard with a ranking of No 114 and he left it having reached the semi-finals alongside Novak Djokovic, Jannik Sinner and Alexander Zverev and established himself among the elite by climbing the rankings to world No 36. Fery's immense semi-final run included him demonstrating his toughness in consecutive incredible five-set comebacks [against Zizou Bergs](#) and [Grigor Dimitrov](#), then showing his sheer quality in his demolition of 6-4, 7-6 (4), 6-0 defeat of [Flavio Cobolli](#). It will be fascinating to see how he follows it up.

Best drama

Jelena Ostapenko and Laura Siegemund are notorious for their combative personalities and they have clashed plenty of times before so it came as no surprise to see them at war again in their mixed-doubles quarter-final match alongside their respective partners, Marcelo Arévalo and Édouard Roger-Vasselin. The dispute started when Siegemund received her second time violation of the match at 7-7 in the second set tie-break after losing the first set 6-4. Siegemund responded by criticising Ostapenko's time-keeping, then refusing to shake Ostapenko's hand at the match's conclusion.

It ended with Ostapenko and Roger-Vasselin arguing by the umpire's chair, with Ostapenko delivering a stinging criticism of Siegemund: "Take the loss a bit better, eh? Learn how to lose."

Most memorable quotes

Players often try to put on a brave face, even after a crushing defeat, but **Alex de Minaur**, the fifth seed, was incredibly candid about the devastation he felt after losing in [straight sets to Cobolli](#) in their fourth-round match. He spoke at length how he is not living up to his lofty ambitions. Some might call him dramatic, but in a sport where even the most successful players lose most weeks, sometimes losses deeply affect them: "It breaks me inside. That's the reality of it. Many, many hours gets put into my craft, and countless years to kind of have moments like these. To not step up to the plate, it's truly gut wrenching. It's very tough."

He continued: "[The losses] just accumulate, right? And kind of the goals, the beliefs, the dreams that you have, they start fading away or they feel a little bit further away than when they once were. A couple of years ago, I was definitely closer to that. Now it just feels like I'm getting a little bit further away from those dreams. I just want [a big run] to keep giving me that hope. If not, this is a tough, tough sport to play with no hope."

Worst luck

There had been so much discussion over whether **Maja Chwalinska**, the [French Open finalist](#), deserved a main draw wildcard. Having received one, she played brilliantly to reach match point against Mananchaya Sawangkaew in their first round match at 6-2, 5-2. Chwalinska then slipped on match point, hurt her ankle and was struggling with the injury and she lost 2-6, 7-5, 6-2.

Most disappointing performance

For a player of **Iga Swiatek**'s calibre, a former No 1 and six-time grand slam champion, a third-round loss anywhere is disappointing. However, much like in her [French Open fourth-round loss to Marta Kostyuk](#), her lack of competitiveness and fight in the second set of her 7-6 (9), 6-2 [loss against the excellent Alexandra Eala](#) was the worst part of her performance. With Swiatek now sitting at No 8 in the WTA rankings and No 12 in the race to the WTA finals, alarm bells should be ringing.

The biggest enemy of progress

Injuries. Serena Williams's singles return provided an [enjoyable evening on Centre Court](#), but the knee injury she suffered meant she could not take to the court [alongside her sister Venus](#), rekindling one of the greatest duos in history. The [injury withdrawals of Emma Raducanu](#) and [Jack Draper on the eve of the tournament](#) were also brutal, particularly considering they were playing well. Victoria Mboko, Holger Rune and Lorenzo Musetti were all missed. Carlos Alcaraz's absence due to a right wrist injury will continue to loom over every significant men's tournament until he returns.

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